

Staying connected

It is important for parents and teens to overcome life’s many distractions in order to spend quality time together. For parents, maintaining a close relationship with a teen who is preprogrammed to separate from them can be tricky, but it helps to be present and willing. Talking about the things that are going well is as helpful as discussing areas of conflict.



◁ **Be inventive**
A chat during a commute can count as quality time.

PARENT TIPS

Building a strong relationship

- Build in regular time together to do something that you both like. Put difficult issues to one side so you can enjoy each other’s company.
- By asking questions and showing interest in your teen, you can improve their self-esteem and make them feel valued. When your teen is speaking, give them your full attention.
- Make clear that your teen can come to you with problems. Be open, not judgmental, and ready to listen. If the timing isn’t right, explain this and schedule a time to talk.
- Talk to your adult friends about their teens to help you keep perspective and clarify in your head what you are prepared to accept.

Encountering problems

Most parent-teen relationships encounter difficulties at some point, but there are practical steps that both sides can take.

▽ **Resolving relationship issues**
If teens or parents feel they can’t cope with a situation themselves, it may be worth seeking help outside the family.

	Situation	Advice
For teens	You feel unsupported when your parents disagree with a decision you’ve made.	Give your parents time to digest your decision. Explain to them how much time you have taken to think things through. They might not agree with every decision you make, but they’ll still love you.
	You feel anxious about opening up to a parent about something personal.	Choose a good time to talk to your parents, when they’re not distracted, and decide in advance what to say. Ask them to help you think about something but to keep an open mind, and to let you finish talking before sharing their opinion.
	You feel worried that you haven’t met your parents’ expectations.	Your parents want the best for you and may not realize how their comments and expectations affect you. Explain to them how they make you feel.
For parents	You feel concerned that your teen is rebelling.	Remember, every teen rebels a bit. Let them know you understand this. Speak to your teen in case worry or angst is the underlying cause of such behavior.
	You feel irritated when your teen compares your parenting style to that of their friends’ parents.	Acknowledge that parenting styles vary between families. Explain to your teen the reasons why your household has certain rules and expectations.
	You feel distant or isolated from your teen.	Stay calm when your teen is distant. Maintain interest in what your teen is doing, and make yourself available so they know you’re there when they want to talk.